

Fail Marks

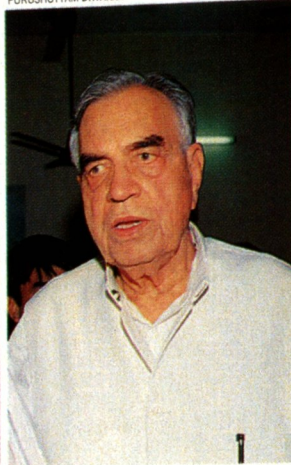
BHOPAL President Pratibha Patil's visit to Madhya Pradesh has turned into an occasion for Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad (ABVP) to voice its protest against Governor Balram Jakhar. ABVP is accusing Jakhar of dragging his feet for over a year on taking action against Kamalakar Singh, the vice-chancellor of a Madhya Pradesh Bhoj (Open) University. Singh is accused of having a forged Ph.D degree, an important qualification to hold his present office. Not only that, he also has a fake law degree.

On the eve of the President's visit, ABVP urged Jakhar, who is also the chancellor of the university, to initiate action against Singh as

PANKAJ TIWARI



PURUSHOTTAM DIWAKAR



FALSE EDUCATION: Singh (left) and Jakhar

per the high court's directives. They threatened to agitate if the governor did not act within six weeks. This initiative is part of ABVP's self-imposed campaign for removing state's tainted vice-chancellors.

There is a genuine case of inordinate delay in taking action against Singh. An inquiry last year

had discovered that two chapters of Singh's thesis were copied and that he had faked his Ph.D. ABVP Madhya Pradesh Secretary Hitesh Shukla blames Jakhar's "favouritism" for Singh's continuance in office for so long despite the charges being proved against him in the high court. **by Mihir Srivastava**

Ticket To Ride

DELHI The West Bengal Government is planning to introduce insurance benefits for the passengers of the 2,000 long-distance state transport buses—probably a subtle way to make bus travel look like a more palatable prospect.

The initial plan was to have passengers using the state transport bus network to pay Rs 5 for a

PIYAL BHATTACHARJEE



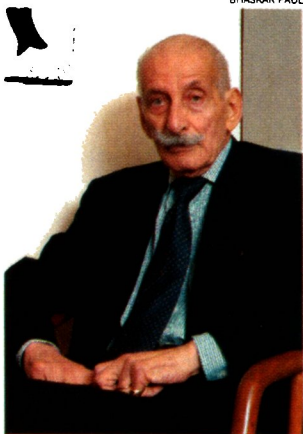
Passengers will be insured

distance of under 300 km and Rs 10 for a 300 km-plus journey towards insurance. However given the fact that all fares on public transport have been increased following the petrol price hike, those plans were shelved. The insurance cover though has stayed. West Bengal Transport Secretary Sumantra Choudhury said that if anyone is killed in a road accident while travelling on government buses, the nearest relative of the deceased will get a compensation of Rs 50,000. "A portion of the bus fare will go towards the creation of an accident fund. No additional fare will be charged from the travellers," Choudhury explained.

Initially, the state Government is implementing this facility only for long-distance buses, and later plans to introduce the scheme in all government-run buses in the state. **by Nandini Vaish**

OBITUARY

BHASKAR PAUL



Field Marshal S.H.F.J. Manekshaw 1914-2008

The phrase "end of an era" is used so loosely these days that is hard to say when one has actually ended. The passing away of India's first field marshal, Sam Hormusji Framji Jamshedji Manekshaw, 94, is truly the end of an epoch. Manekshaw was a soldier drop-forged in the fires of the Second World War—he was injured in combat twice and nearly died on the battlefield after being hit by Japanese machine gun fire in his stomach during the Burma campaign. He would later joke that if a man said he was not afraid of dying, he was either probably lying or was a Gorkha. But that was 'Sam Bahadur'—as the Gorkha regiment officer was affectionately called. Never afraid of speaking his mind, Manekshaw led from the front throughout his four-decade career. His candour did get him into some trouble. He was nearly court-martialled for alleged loose talk but

instead was sent by prime minister Jawaharlal Nehru to boost the morale of a defeated army in the aftermath of the 1962 Indo-China war. As eastern army commander six years later, he contained a difficult insurrection in Nagaland. But perhaps his greatest battle lay as India's eighth army chief, in convincing prime minister Indira Gandhi into delaying an offensive into erstwhile East Pakistan. The decision, which finally happened at the time of the Indian Army's choosing, led to the surrender of 93,000 Pakistani troops and saw the birth of Bangladesh. It was one of the Cold War's most momentous geopolitical events and India's greatest military victory. The legend and the legacy of this great Indian military icon will continue to inspire long after the politicians and military leaders who failed to turn up at his state funeral, have passed on.

by Sandeep Unnithan